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Bazaar

Cowon EH2

High fidelity, with a hefty price tag

The prospect of reviewing earphones from Cowon is always something to look forward to; not because Cowon is known for stellar quality or has had consistently brilliant releases – that's not the reason. The prospect is exciting because there's always the possibility of discovering gems like the EMI. The EMI as you probably know is a budget segment performer that's been our most recommended headphone for a long while now.

A look at the packaging and the headphones themselves quickly answered the "budget" part of my earlier query. No, these were certainly not going to be budget headphones. Thirty seconds into putting them on and I realised we're dealing with something way different here. The clarity and detail was such that it was time to upgrade the league a bit and bring out the slightly bigger guns for comparison. So out came the Aurvana 2 as well as our old favourite – the Martin Logan Micros 70.

I decided to hook up the FiiO E11K Kilimanjaro to a Nexus 5 for one round of test tracks followed by our old faithful Xonar Essence STX for the next round.

Features and build

The most interesting bundled accessory with the EH2 wasn't the carry sleeve or the 1/4-inch adapter, it was the assortment of tips. There were three sizes and two types. Apart from the regular ones you get tips that have a bit of foam lining behind the flange. This provides more resistance or push back against your ear canal, therefore a better seal and better isolation.

This being a hybrid headphone, it houses two drivers. One, a balanced armature design driver and the other a regular dynamic driver. The balanced armature driver tackles the highs while the dynamic driver produces the bass frequencies.

The headphone reminded us of the XBA 3 which had not just two but three discrete drivers. While having more drivers than just one full range driver does seem to be a feature that many in-ears seem to be sporting these days. We even have with us the UE 900 which has quad drivers – that's four drivers to each ear. Still whatever the number of drivers it's ultimately the performance that matters. So let's get down to the part that really matters.

Performance

Having tried different sources with the EH2, one thing is apparent right away – the detail is phenomenal. While the higher end of the spectrum is greatly enhanced somehow they still manage to sound sweet and not shrill – typical of the sound signature we've noticed on similarly tuned in-ears like the Klipsch Image S4i, for example.

The performance and fidelity is truly superlative. Halfway through the test I began switching between the Bose QuietComfort 20i and the UE 900 for drawing comparisons. While the Bose QC 20 has that please-all sort of sound signature, I found that the EH2

had its mid range slightly less emphasised. The EH2 therefore is decidedly bright. The bass isn't punchy or hard hitting, but in no way can the headphone be described as bass shy. For flat response enthusiasts (who usually don't like too much boom in their audio) this headphone will be much loved.

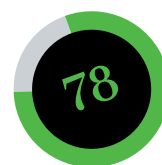
But of course it can't all be great. Having the mid ranges suppressed some of your tracks especially those driven by vocals won't sound that great. Take for example the velvety smooth baritone timbre of Chris Rea's voice. While listening to Chris Rea's Call On Me, the warm, full-bodied rasp of his vocals is lost. So yes, while the EH2 handles the instrument density of rock and metal numbers beautifully, with perfect separation and detail, I wouldn't recommend it for country or similar genres.

Verdict

Quite simply if you are even a little serious about quality and the kind of audio experience you subject your ears to, you have to get yourself the EH2. The price puts it squarely between the likes of the Aurvana 2, Micros 70, XBA 3 which cost around ₹8000 on one side and extreme high end ones like the UE900 and QC20i which cost upwards of ₹25,000. What's surprising and delightful is that the performance of the Cowon EH2 is closer to those 25k headphones than it is to the 8k band. Bottomline: if you can afford it go for it. It's an audiophile collectible.

Siddharth Parwatay

Price
₹14,500



Features.....	77
Performance.....	85
Build.....	77
Value.....	72

Specifications

Impedance: 32 ohm; **Rated power:** 3mW; **Max Power:** 100mW; **Sensitivity:** 105dB; **Frequency response:** 20Hz - 22,000Hz; **Cord:** 1.2m

Contact

Lipap Systems
Phone: 022-29271307
Email: iaudio@lipap.com
Website: www.cowonindia.in